

7/15/26

Good evening. My name is Monica Strauser, and I am a Kennett Township resident.

I request that the substance of my comments be reflected in the minutes, and I am providing my written remarks for the public record.

I am speaking tonight on behalf of a petition signed by **353 verified Township residents** asking the Board not to make another irreversible commitment to the municipal expansion project until the public planning is complete.

I want to thank Supervisor Bailey for acknowledging on June 17 that the Township needs a document explaining the rationale for current and future police staffing before the final building vote. He subsequently wrote that it should be completed within two to three months and presented at a future Board meeting.

That is meaningful progress. But a recommendation is not yet a Board commitment.

Residents still do not know what that document will contain, whether the Board will formally approve the police service and staffing assumptions, whether meaningful alternatives will be compared, or whether design, borrowing, bidding, and other project commitments may continue while that work is underway.

The recently published feasibility study demonstrates why this matters.

The study contains valuable information about the condition of the existing building, police facility needs, possible building locations, and projected construction costs. But it answers a narrower question than many residents may realize.

The Township's information page says the study considered expanding the existing building, constructing a supplemental building on the existing property, or constructing one on another property.

But the final report states that every developed option retained the existing Township Building for administration and public meetings and proposed construction of a new police facility.

In other words, the study compared different locations and configurations for moving the Police Department. It does not appear to have fully studied the opposite alternative: converting the existing building primarily into a police station and relocating some or all administrative functions.

That is a significant unanswered question because the study also concludes that the existing building is generally in good condition.

A more fundamental master-planning question should have been asked:

**Given the assets the Township already owns, which functions should occupy the existing building, and what is the smallest amount of new construction needed to accommodate the remainder?**

The feasibility study may identify the preferred location for a new police building, assuming a new 11,500-square-foot police building is the chosen policy. But it does not establish that this is the smallest, least costly, or best long-term solution for the Township as a whole.

That is precisely why the facility decision cannot be separated from a police service and staffing strategy.

Additionally, residents still do not understand the project's full financial impact: the Township repeatedly cites a roughly \$10 million "all-in" figure, while its own feasibility study identifies an additional \$2.1 million in soft costs and approximately \$2.45 million in future renovations to the existing building after the police move. Making it closer to \$15 million all in. These costs must be clearly reconciled before any final commitment.

I therefore ask Supervisor Bailey; or another member of the Board; to make a motion directing the Township Manager to prepare and publish a **Police Facility Transparency and Strategic Plan**, including:

- a Board-approved police service and staffing strategy;
- population, housing, workload, revenue, debt, and tax projections;
- a room-by-room justification of the proposed facility;
- reduced-scope, adaptive-reuse, and phased alternatives with full lifecycle costs;
- a dedicated public work session before final project authorization.

The motion should also state that the Board will not authorize construction bids, borrowing, or another irreversible phase until that information has been presented publicly and considered by the Board.

A motion matters because it establishes exactly what must be produced, who is responsible, and when the public will receive it. It also gives all three supervisors an opportunity to state clearly whether they support this process.

We support correcting the deficiencies in the police facility. But the order matters:

**Decide the service model. Establish the need. Compare the alternatives. Understand the full cost. Then approve the building.**

Supervisor Bailey has recommended that a staffing-rationale document be completed before the final building vote. I appreciate that recommendation.

Now I ask the Board to turn it into a clear and enforceable public commitment.

**Please make the motion tonight, or place it on the next agenda for a public vote.**